

2
IN THE BEGINNING, JUST WAR AND CRICKET

BY THE time I started walking, sometime in the early 1980s, Pakistan was crazy about just three sports: cricket, hockey and squash. Cricket was the most popular of them, and more accessible, as it could be played on the streets. It was more appealing too because there were a lot of stars at the time in the Pakistan team who inspired young men, even women, to play the sport.

Like millions of others in my generation, my star was Imran Khan. I started playing cricket because of him. Like him, I fancied myself as a fast bowler, though unlike many, I never tried to mimic his action. However, when I realized that my bowling action was problematic – I'd chuck the ball when I bowled pace – I quit fast bowling.

Like any other middle-class kid in Pakistan, I started playing in the neighbourhood, on the streets. The area I lived in, the roughshod Federal 'B' Area of Karachi, Pakistan's former capital and now its most troubled megacity with over 20 million people, wasn't as violent in the '80s as it is today and a lot of first-class cricketers lived there at the time.

I remember that my vicinity, Block 10, a warm neighbourhood where everyone knew each other, had a lot of cricketers. Haroon Rasheed, who played several Tests in the '70s for Pakistan and is credited for discovering Waqar Younis, was my neighbour and an inspiration. So was my elder brother, Tariq, who played first-class cricket and was a very quick pace bowler during his playing days.

Like many middle-class South Asian parents, my father, Sahibzada Fazal Rehman Afridi – God bless his soul – was not very happy about my interest in cricket. My family had traditionally always been in business or the armed forces. The ups and downs and unpredictability of cricket didn't fit into my father's world of trying to make a stable, honest living, as is the Pashtun way. He would be livid when I would come back home after hours and give me plenty of flak for wasting my day, for letting the outdoors darken my complexion and for not hitting the books